I still remember that evening. Gertrude told me on a later occasion that I seemed to be looking at her constantly and to be unaware of anything else.

Yes, indeed! She was exactly right!

Joe was in charge, so the date did not follow along the lines they usually did when I was in charge. The first place we went to was a bar.

"What do you want?" said Joe to me, expansively.

I looked uncertain and miserable, and whispered to him, "What am I supposed to have?"

He took in the situation and whispered back, "Have a half-and-half. That's very mild."

I didn't know what a half-and-half was. I said, "Sure."

So I got it and sipped it and it tasted like beer, so I hated it and just held it wondering what to do next. Meanwhile, everyone lit up a cigarette, including Gertrude, and Joe offered me one. I took it, he lit it, and now I had something in my other hand.

Gertrude watched me as I desperately sipped and tried to swallow and then, just as desperately, puffed and tried not to choke. She said, "You don't drink, do you?"

I shook my head miserably.

"You don't smoke either, do you?"

I shook my head again.

"Why are you trying to, then?"

I said, "I don't want to spoil things."

She said, "You won't spoil things."

So I put down the half-and-half and stepped on the cigarette. I felt much better after that.

On a later occasion, Gertrude told me that she had always led a most circumspect life (and so she had) and that I was the first person she had ever